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Culture (OWC): **Mbuti (FO04)**

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Central Africa

Field Date: 1970-1973 (P. Viii)

Coverage Date: Ca. 1876-1960

Place Coverage: Not Specified

Section Title(S)

POWER AND AUTHORITY • THE PRETENSE OF SUBSERVIENCE

Once, when I was very ill, I came out of a coma to find him sitting at the foot of my bed. He said something about the spirits of the ancestors walking across my chest. Then he just sat and stared at me with unblinking eyes until I drifted off to sleep. When I woke up some hours later, he was gone and I was on my way to recovery.

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Material Not Relevant

His first wife had died not long after they were married. Mandevu then took an Mbuti wife, and this was another quality that singled him out as someone special, for through his wife he had access to the supernatural power of the forest as well as that which he could reach through his village ancestry. By his Mbuti wife he had one son, Katchelewa. I have known Katchelewa since he was an infant. He is at home in the forest just as he is in the village, and is already on the way to becoming a prophet, like his father.

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Material Not Relevant

The need that Mandevu filled was the need for the reaffirmation of some commonly held values at a time when the combined forces of colonialism, commercialism, and missionary endeavor were threatening to sweep away all that made life worthwhile for the villagers. The more critical the crisis became, as independence approached, and through the Simba revolution, the more powerful Mandevu became. People would gather around him to make decisions. He would say nothing, just watch and listen in his quiet way. And when the decision was made, although he had said nothing, people would say it was his.

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Material Not Relevant

THE PRETENSE OF SUBSERVIENCE

No matter what the character of any village was, and though the degree to which villagers attempted to control and exploit the Mbuti varied greatly, the forest world of the Mbuti remained constant. Only the stories they brought back about the upside-down world of the village varied. Some villages, however, were more attractive to the Mbuti. In fact, being on the losing end of a bargain in which they were the only ones in real economic need, most villagers went out of their way to placate the Mbuti, since they could not directly coerce them.

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What the Mbuti liked best of all was a village that they took to be the best of the outside world, but with the least amount of pressure attached to it. There they put the classical joking relationship into action in a masterful way. Rather than bartering or trading, as villagers did, the Mbuti brought their *kpara* and *karé* ("brothers of the knife," village men with whom they had shared the *nkumbi* initiation) whatever they chose to bring by way of forest products, and did just as much work as they wanted to, in return helping themselves to whatever they wanted from their patrons' households or plantations. If the village was at a strategic point along the road, there might be a small local "hotel" for truck drivers to stay overnight, or a store selling a few trade goods, including cigarettes, and another selling beer. The Mbuti played their games there as well, finding as much pleasure in the situation when an irate villager refused to give them any more

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